ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Advanced present forms

Use present forms for commentary, narrative immediacy, temporary behaviour, trends and performative acts. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use advanced present forms to choose a present tense according to discourse viewpoint rather than clock time alone while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use present forms for commentary, narrative immediacy, temporary behaviour, trends and performative acts.

MODEL

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

present simple/continuous + discourse function

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main advanced present forms patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses choose a present tense according to discourse viewpoint rather than clock time alone.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in narrative, commentary, journalism, instruction and formal interaction.

Build meaning before form

Use present forms for commentary, narrative immediacy, temporary behaviour, trends and performative acts.

What advanced present forms communicates

Use present forms for commentary, narrative immediacy, temporary behaviour, trends and performative acts.

The central purpose is to choose a present tense according to discourse viewpoint rather than clock time alone. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.	past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint
The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.	repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker
I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.	an utterance that performs the named formal action

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: present simple/continuous + discourse function. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Historic present	present simple in past narrative	So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.
Temporary behaviour	be + always/constantly + -ing	The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.
Performative present	present simple reporting the act itself	I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint	Historic present
repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker	Temporary behaviour
an utterance that performs the named formal action	Performative present

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in narrative, commentary, journalism, instruction and formal interaction. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02
present simple/continuous	discourse function

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: choose a present tense according to discourse viewpoint rather than clock time alone.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits narrative, commentary, journalism, instruction and formal interaction.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Historic present	present simple in past narrative	So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.
Temporary behaviour	be + always/constantly + -ing	The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.
Performative present	present simple reporting the act itself	I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.	past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint
The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.	repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker
I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.	an utterance that performs the named formal action

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not shift between historic present and past without a clear viewpoint reason.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not assume always plus continuous is a neutral permanent habit.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use the continuous for a conventional performative act.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint?

OPTIONS So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment. · The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts. · I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker?

OPTIONS The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts. · I acknowledge receipt of your complaint. · So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an utterance that performs the named formal action?

OPTIONS I acknowledge receipt of your complaint. · So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment. · The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint · repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker · an utterance that performs the named formal action

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker · an utterance that performs the named formal action · past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an utterance that performs the named formal action · past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint · repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Historic present / Temporary behaviour / Performative present · Gap 2: past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint / repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker / an utterance that performs the named formal action

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Temporary behaviour / Performative present / Historic present · Gap 2: repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker / an utterance that performs the named formal action / past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Performative present / Historic present / Temporary behaviour · Gap 2: an utterance that performs the named formal action / past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint / repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint: _____. Choose the model that expresses repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker: _____. Choose the model that expresses an utterance that performs the named formal action: _____. Choose the model built with present simple in past narrative: _____. Choose the model built with be + always/constantly + -ing: _____. Choose the model built with present simple reporting the act itself: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint. · So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment. · The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

So _____, and it contains the missing attachment. The new system _____ duplicate alerts. _____ receipt of your complaint. State the full structural pattern for Historic present: _____. State the full structural pattern for Temporary behaviour: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “I opened the message and found the attachment.” using the Historic present pattern to express past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The system repeatedly generates unwanted duplicate alerts.” using the Temporary behaviour pattern to express repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “By saying this, the writer formally acknowledges receipt.” using the Performative present pattern to express an utterance that performs the named formal action.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “I opened the message and found the attachment.” using the Historic present pattern to express past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Historic present to express past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Temporary behaviour to express repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Performative present to express an utterance that performs the named formal action, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

Historic present is the best match because past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint.

A2

The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

Temporary behaviour is the best match because repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker.

A3

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

Performative present is the best match because an utterance that performs the named formal action.

A4

past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint

The Historic present pattern communicates past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint.

A5

repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker

The Temporary behaviour pattern communicates repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker.

A6

an utterance that performs the named formal action

The Performative present pattern communicates an utterance that performs the named formal action.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Historic present / past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint

The structure belongs to the Historic present pattern. Its communicative purpose is past events retold with immediate narrative viewpoint.

B2

Temporary behaviour / repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker

The structure belongs to the Temporary behaviour pattern. Its communicative purpose is repeated temporary behaviour often evaluated by the speaker.

B3

Performative present / an utterance that performs the named formal action

The structure belongs to the Performative present pattern. Its communicative purpose is an utterance that performs the named formal action.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

Historic present: present simple in past narrative.

C2

The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

Temporary behaviour: be + always/constantly + -ing.

C3

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

Performative present: present simple reporting the act itself.

C4

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

Historic present: present simple in past narrative.

C5

The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

Temporary behaviour: be + always/constantly + -ing.

C6

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

Performative present: present simple reporting the act itself.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

I open the message

Historic present requires “I open the message” in this model. present simple in past narrative.

D2

is constantly generating

Temporary behaviour requires “is constantly generating” in this model. be + always/constantly + -ing.

D3

I acknowledge

Performative present requires “I acknowledge” in this model. present simple reporting the act itself.

D4

present simple in past narrative

Historic present is built as present simple in past narrative.

D5

be + always/constantly + -ing

Temporary behaviour is built as be + always/constantly + -ing.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

present simple in past narrative. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended historic present effect.

E2

The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts.

be + always/constantly + -ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended temporary behaviour effect.

E3

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint.

present simple reporting the act itself. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended performative present effect.

E4

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment.

present simple in past narrative. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended historic present effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

So I open the message, and it contains the missing attachment. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses present simple in past narrative accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The new system is constantly generating duplicate alerts. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses be + always/constantly + -ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

I acknowledge receipt of your complaint. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses present simple reporting the act itself accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____